

CASE STUDY · TRAVEL & COMMERCE · STRATEGIC PLANNING

A business in decline doesn't need a better plan.

It needs *alignment on what the plan is for.*

COMPANY	BUSINESS UNIT	FORMAT	OUTPUT
Global Travel Platform (TripAdvisor)	Vacation Rentals	3-Day Cross-Functional Strategy Off-site	FY19 Strategic Roadmap

OUTCOME *100% of attendees agreed the off-site met its objectives. The cross-functional team left Oxford with a shared diagnosis, prioritized opportunity areas, and clear ownership — for the first time.*

THE VIEWPOINT STACK™ — LAYERS ENGAGED

LAYER 1

Leadership Alignment

Brought a newly restructured, cross-functional leadership team into shared diagnosis for the first time — creating a common view of where the business stood and what it would take to turn it around.

LAYER 2

Organizational Clarity

Used structured prioritization and roles-and-responsibilities mapping to move from a long list of ideas to clear ownership — ensuring every major opportunity area had a defined lead and next steps before the team left the room.

LAYER 3

Operational Infrastructure

Built the operating infrastructure for strategy itself — pre-read framework, facilitated session architecture, daily reflection cadence, and a parking lot process — that became a repeatable model for how the VR team ran strategy work going forward.

THE SITUATION

The vacation rentals business was losing ground — and the team didn't have a shared view of *why*.

TripAdvisor's Vacation Rentals business was under real pressure. Site traffic was down 13% year-over-year. Bookings had declined 33–37% YoY across every booking type. Only 18% of available listings had received a booking that year — despite nearly one million properties on platform. Airbnb and VRBO were pulling ahead.

The harder problem wasn't the numbers. It was that a newly restructured, cross-functional product team — spanning product management, engineering, design, analytics, SEO, supply, and customer success — had never had dedicated time to align on the business, the customer, or a shared direction for the year ahead. They were executing, but not toward a common vision.

There was no shortage of smart people with opinions about what to fix. What was missing was a structured process to get those opinions into the room, surface the real blockers, and turn a list of problems into a strategy the whole team could own.

−13% SITE TRAFFIC YOY Declining across desktop, mobile, tablet, and app ahead of the off-site.	−37% BOOKINGS YOY TIP bookings — the primary revenue driver — had been in steady decline since January.	18% LISTINGS WITH A BOOKING Of ~1 million available listings, fewer than 1 in 5 had generated a booking that year.
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— THE INTERVENTION

Three days in Oxford. One goal: leave with *a strategy the team actually built together*.

The off-site was designed and led as a structured facilitation — not a leadership presentation with Q&A, but a genuine working session in which the cross-functional team would diagnose the business, explore the opportunity space, and converge on priorities together. The design choices were deliberate:

- Commissioned and compiled a comprehensive pre-read — a current state assessment covering KPIs, competitive landscape, customer research, and brand health — distributed in advance so the team arrived informed, not catching up
- Built a 3-day agenda sequenced from current-state reflection → opportunity exploration → prioritization and ownership, so the team moved through divergence to convergence rather than generating ideas without resolution
- Designed break-out sessions around specific customer and business questions — traffic acquisition, loyalty, supply utilization, TA ecosystem integration, data science — each grounded in a clear problem statement with a designated owner
- Facilitated a brand exploration session to surface and challenge assumptions about the VR value proposition and whether the existing multi-brand architecture was serving or undermining the business
- Closed with a structured opportunity prioritization (dot voting and gap analysis) and a roles and responsibilities mapping, so the team left Oxford with clear owners — not just ideas
- Ran a daily "Reflection" session to surface parking lot items, prevent loose ends from accumulating, and ensure the agenda stayed relevant to what the team actually needed

— THE RESULT

A team that arrived with questions left with *a shared strategy and the ownership to execute it*.

The post-event survey told a clear story: 100% of the 18 attendees agreed the off-site met its objectives. Not a single person was dissatisfied — with the structure, the session topics, the facilitation, or the event overall. 61% were "very satisfied" overall; 55% "strongly agreed" the event was well-structured.

More importantly, the team left with what they came for: a shared diagnosis of the business, a prioritized set of opportunity areas with clear owners, and the cross-functional relationships needed to execute faster. The open strategic questions — who is our customer, what is our value proposition, where should we invest — moved from unspoken assumptions to explicit choices the team had made together.

The format itself became a model. 83% of attendees said they wanted sessions like this at least every six months — and the structured approach to pre-reads, facilitated divergence, and ownership mapping carried forward into how the VR product team ran strategy work going forward.

"I was impressed with the organization, thought and preparation put into the event — from the pre-read deck to the brainstorm sessions."

OFF-SITE PARTICIPANT, VR STRATEGY TEAM

"The structure and agenda were perfect for the group size. The breadth of people and backgrounds was a strong contribution to making the presentations and discussions very valuable."

OFF-SITE PARTICIPANT, VR STRATEGY TEAM

100%

AGREED OBJECTIVES WERE MET

Zero dissatisfied attendees across all survey dimensions — structure, topics, facilitation, and overall experience.

30+

ATTENDEES, 8 FUNCTIONS

Product, engineering, design, analytics, SEO, supply, CS, and finance — aligned in the same room for the first time.

83%

WANTED THIS EVERY 6 MONTHS

The format became a template — structured strategic sessions adopted as a recurring practice for the VR team.



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